

# The past, Brexit, and the future in Northern Ireland: a quasi-experiment

Replication and Extension (Assignment POP77082)

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# Outline

- 1 Original Study
- 2 Replication Results
- 3 My Contribution: Extensions

# The Original Study: Research Question

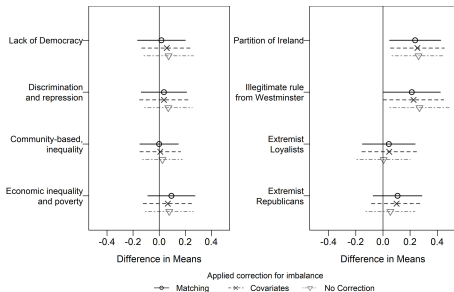
- **Authors:** Godefroidt, Dyrstad & Bakke (2023).
- **Goal:** Test the effect of the Brexit referendum outcome on:
  - ① Perceptions of the causes of *The Troubles*.
  - ② Constitutional preferences for Northern Ireland.
- **Mechanism:** Brexit as a key factor that reactivates memories of political and economic instability.

## Exogenous Shock

The referendum (June 23, 2016) took place **during** the fieldwork of the *Post-conflict Attitudes for Peace* (PAP) survey.

- **Control Group:** Surveyed before June 23.
- **Treatment Group:** Surveyed after the "Leave" outcome was known.
- **Method:** Entropy Balancing (EB) to ensure comparability between groups.

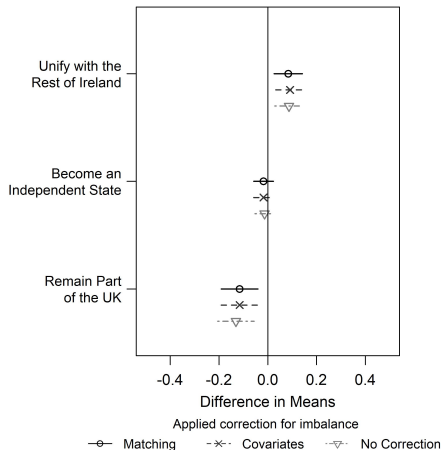
# Replication: Perception of Causes (Fig 1)



- Significant increase in the perceived importance of **Westminster rule** and the **partition of Ireland**.

# Replication: Constitutional Preferences (Fig 2 & 3)

- **Irish Unification:** +9 percentage point increase.
- **Remain in UK:** -13 percentage point drop.
- **Independence:** No significant change.



# The Extension: Heterogeneous Effects

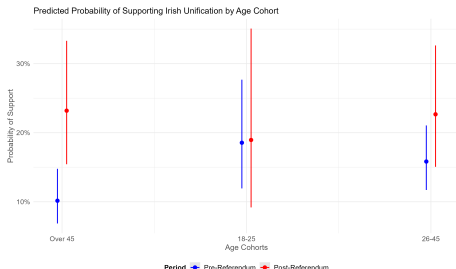
**Research Question:** Is the Brexit effect uniform or does it vary by demographic profile?

## Interaction Models (GLM Logit)

$$\text{Unification} \sim \text{Referendum} \times \text{Moderator} + \text{Controls}$$

- **Moderator 1:** Age Cohorts (18-25, 26-45, Over 45).
- **Moderator 2:** Exposure to the Troubles (Victims vs Non-victims).
- **Moderator 3:** Gender (Male vs Female).

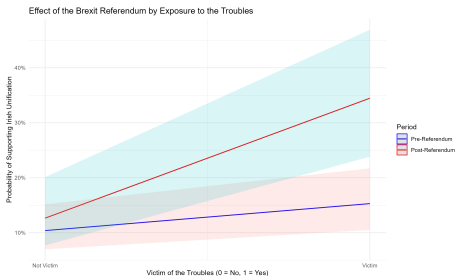
# Extension 1: Age Cohorts



- **Result:** Non-significant interaction.
- **Interpretation:** Brexit acted as a **universal systemic shock**.
- The "jump" is parallel across all cohorts, though the Over 45s show a more precise doubling of support.

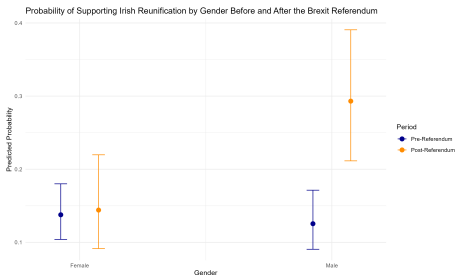


## Extension 2: Exposure to the Troubles



- **Result:** Significant interaction ( $p < 0.05$ ).
- **Interpretation:** The referendum had a **stronger effect on victims**.
- Personal trauma acts as a catalyst for political change when stability is threatened.

# Extension 3: Gender



- **Result:** Significant interaction.
- **Interpretation:** Effect considerably stronger for **men**.
- Possible reasons: Risk aversion in women or stronger link between masculinity and nationalist mobilization.

- The replication confirms the robust impact of the Brexit shock on Northern Irish public opinion.
- **Contribution:** My extension shows that the effect was not socially neutral:
  - It is **gendered** (stronger in men).
  - It is **trauma-sensitive** (stronger in victims).
  - But it is **generationally homogeneous** in its reaction.

# Bibliography I